

Session 19: Humanity Fails the Test

Key Takeaways

- Humans fail by trying to make themselves gods instead of trusting God.
- The humans' failure in the garden is folly because they tried to seize from God what he had already freely offered them.

The Dialogue Between the Snake and the Woman

In [Genesis 3:1](#), notice how the snake first twists the divine command in [Genesis 2:16-17](#) so that God's generosity ("eat from all the trees of the garden") is portrayed as protective scarcity. His first tactic is to undermine God's character by creating an easy opportunity for correction.

"The serpent's obvious inaccuracy in his rendition of God's prohibition sounds like cunning or lack of subtlety. In fact, it is a well-known trick of the con man to appear stupid to put others in a position of sham superiority. Any hustler knows that she better start by losing some games and give the impression to other that they will be easy winners."

Lacoque, Andre (2006). *The Trial of Innocence: Adam, Eve, and the Yahwist*. Cascade Books.

In [Genesis 3:2-3](#), the woman responds by correcting the snake, and she clarifies that God invited them to eat from all of the trees except one. The snake has directed the conversation so that the single prohibition now becomes the focus. She first provides God's rationale for avoiding the tree—choosing to eat from it will constitute an act of rebellious autonomy, taking into one's own hands the wisdom and authority to discern between good and bad.

In [Genesis 3:4-5](#), the snake's response is to offer an alternative interpretation of both God's words and his intentions. God is actually withholding an ultimate good from his creatures, preventing them from becoming "like *Elohim*."

"In Genesis 2-3, Adam and Eve's sin is a departure from a relationship of love and trust of their creator. The serpent offers them a fake deification; a tragic imitation of a divine nature that they already have. They are already God's divine image (both in Gen. 1:26–28 and also in Gen. 2.), carrying the divine breath (2:7), with divine privileges (such as the ability to name parts of creation as God himself did on Days 1-3) and wisdom (see esp. 2:25 where they are עֶרְוָה: 'naked' or 'shrewd'). God has already showed them the difference between good and evil and would continue to guide them in that discernment. They are the image-idols of the creator Yahweh God, the serpent offers them a shot at becoming only like 'gods' (*elohim*, so, correctly, the LXX). In apparent ignorance or forgetfulness of—or in rebellion against—their true identity they fall prey to the serpent's insinuations that their creator had deceived them (Gen. 3:1-5). The tree that should have proved their discernment between wrongdoing and faithfulness to God, becomes instead a tree that leads

to their experience of both evil and, lingering, good. In the same way that idolaters become like what they worship (Ps. 115:4-8; 135:15-18), so the humans become like the (leaf-clad) tree (3:7). They give up the splendor of their creator, inclining to the voice of the creature, and are left bereft of the glory that was theirs by rights. Their action strikes at the heart of their identity. In succumbing to the lie that they need something they already have, they annihilate themselves, and, so, 'after sin there is nothing for it but death.'

Fletcher-Louis, Crispin (2012). "2 Enoch and the New Perspective on Apocalyptic". In *New Perspectives on 2 Enoch: No Longer Slavonic Only*. Brill.

The Inverted Symmetry of Genesis 3:6-7

The Act

- a 6 and the woman saw that **the tree** **was good** **for eating** ,
 b and that it was desirable to **the eyes** ,
 and that the tree was desirable **to make one wise** ,
 c and **she took** from its fruit and **she ate** ;
 c' and **she gave** also to her husband with her, and **he ate** .
 b' 7a **and the eyes of both of them were opened** ,

Naked and Ashamed

- 7b and **they knew** that they were **naked** (ערום);
 a' and they sewed **leaves of a fig tree** together and made themselves loin coverings.

Genesis 2:25-3:7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

What the woman sees is filled out in three steps.

1. "And she saw that [it] ... was good": This is in deliberate contrast to God's "seeing that it is good" seven times over in Genesis 1:1-2:3.
2. "Desirable (תאוה) to the eyes": What the woman sees generates desire. She now "wants" the thing that will kill her because she has embraced the snake's alternate narrative. Instead of realizing her true desire will only be fulfilled by trusting God and eating from the tree of life (see [Prov. 13:12](#)), she mistakes the tree's beauty for the creator it points to.
3. "Desirable (נחמד 'to covet') for becoming wise (שכל)": By embracing the snake's interpretation of the tree, she sees the knowing of good and bad as desirable and a path to true wisdom. In reality, it is the path of folly that will lead to death.

"Precisely at this point the author raises the issue of becoming 'wise': 'And the woman saw that the tree was also desirable for gaining wisdom' (3:6). Thus, the temptation is not presented as a general rebellion from God's authority. Rather, it is portrayed as a quest for wisdom and 'the good' apart from God's provision."

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [*The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-theological Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic.

Notice that the snake was not lying about “the eyes being opened” but about what kind of enlightenment would result. The humans become aware of their own nakedness and vulnerability with each other and hide their bodies from one another.

Their folly and rebellion was caused by their idolatrous desire for a forbidden tree, so now the humans become like trees, covering their bodies with leaves.

Reflection Question

The snake casts doubt on God’s goodness and generosity by implying that God is depriving humanity of good things. Compare the snake’s words in Genesis 3:4-5 to God’s command in Genesis 2:16-17. What does God say in his original command that shows the snake is wrong about God’s generosity?